
Personal Essay

Module II Writing
Oct 2025



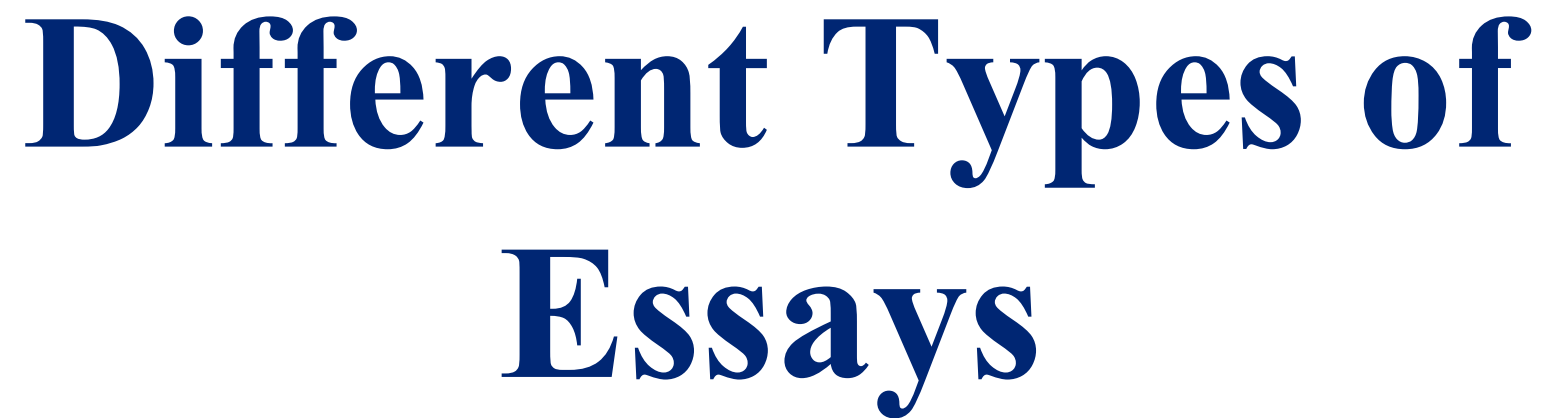
Agenda

1. Common English essay types

2. Personal essay

- ◆ Intellectual content
- ◆ Organization / Outline
- ◆ Language use





Six Common Types of Writing

1. **Reflective Essay**
2. **Expository (means explanatory) Essay**
3. **Descriptive Essay**
4. **Persuasive Essay**
5. **Narrative Essay**
6. **Argumentative Essay**



Task 1. Essay Type Matching Game

- ◆ Instructions: Match each essay type with its corresponding definition (5 mins).



Six Common Types of Writing

1. **Narrative Essay:** This type of essay tells a story or recounts an event. It often includes characters, a **plot**, and a setting, and it aims to engage readers by creating a **vivid experience** for them.
2. **Descriptive Essay:** Descriptive essays focus on providing a **detailed description** of a person, place, object, or event. The goal is to paint a clear and sensory-rich **picture** for readers.
3. **Expository Essay:** Expository essays aim to **explain or inform**. They present facts, statistics, and evidence to provide a clear and objective analysis of a topic. Examples include cause and effect essays, compare and contrast essays, and process essays.
4. **Persuasive Essay:** In persuasive essays, the writer's goal is to **convince** readers to adopt a particular viewpoint or take a specific action. Strong arguments, evidence, and logical reasoning are essential in persuasive writing.
5. **Argumentative Essay:** Similar to persuasive essays, argumentative essays require the writer to present arguments and evidence but also acknowledge **counterarguments**. The goal is to **establish a well-reasoned position** on a topic.
6. **Reflective Essay:** Reflective essays require the writer to **reflect** on personal experiences or growth. They explore what was learned from these experiences and how they have influenced the writer.

Think about the following questions:

- ◆ 1. Do these essay types overlap?
- ◆ 2. Which type of essay does a personal essay belong in?



1. Do they overlap?

i. Argumentative vs. Persuasive Essays

While **argumentative essays** primarily focus on proving a claim's **validity or rationality through objective logic, evidence, and reasoning**, **persuasive essays** rely more on **emotional appeals and personal conviction** to influence the reader's perspective.



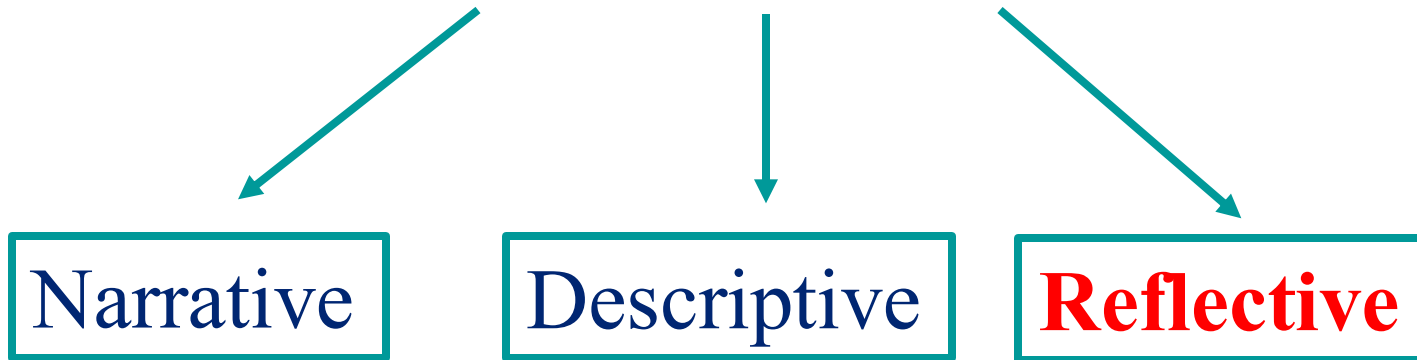
1. Do they overlap?

ii. Descriptive vs. Narrative Essays (Pictures VS Movies)

A narrative essay typically **tells a story**, but it may include **descriptive elements** to create a more **vivid and engaging narrative**. Likewise, a descriptive essay may incorporate **narrative elements** to make the description more relatable.



2. What type does a **personal essay** belong in?



- ◆ A personal essay may be a **narrative essay** that tells a story, but it may include **descriptive elements** to create a more vivid and engaging narrative.
- ◆ A personal essay should also include the writer's **personal insights and reflections** on how they have **learned, changed, or grown** in some way.



Personal essays VS pure narrative essays

- **Example topic: My fear of public speaking**
- **Narrative essay:**
 - “The day I conquered my fear of public speaking”
- **Personal essay:**
 - “How overcoming my fear of public speaking changed my life”



Key differences between **personal essays** and **pure narrative essays**

- ◆ **Reflection vs. Storytelling:**
- ◆ **Personal essays** are more reflective, focusing on the writer's **thoughts, feelings, and personal growth.**
- ◆ **Narrative essays** emphasize the elements of **storytelling and plot development.**



Personal Essays

I. Intellectual Content



Definition

- ◆ A personal essay is a concise written piece that allows writers to 1) vividly portray a **personal experience** or **significant event** based on their **perspective** or **worldview** and 2) share the **significance** of the experience/event in their life or their **growth** from it.
- ◆ A personal essay seamlessly integrates 1) **engaging narration**, 2) **vivid description**, and 3) **introspective reflection**.



Personal Essay Example Topic

The Biggest Challenge in My Life



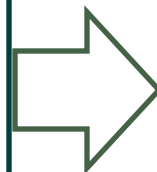
I. Intellectual Content

◆ What is your biggest challenge?

When and where did it occur?

How did it make you feel?

How did it affect your daily life?



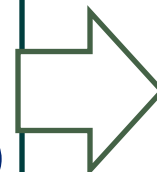
Narrations and descriptions

◆ How did you overcome the challenge?

What was your first reaction? (Avoidance? Anger? Denial?)

What was the turning point? (A person? A special moment?)

What did you do? (List concrete actions.)



Narrations and descriptions

◆ What did you learn about yourself from this experience?

How did it impact/change your mindset or behavior?

In what situations have you applied this lesson since then?



Reflections



II. Organization



How to organize a personal essay?

INTRODUCTION

Ends with a thesis statement

BODY

I. MAIN POINT

Topic sentence & evidence

A. Subordinate point (level 1)

1. Subordinate point (level 2)

a. Subordinate point (level 3)

b. Subordinate point (level 3)

i. Subordinate point (level 4)

ii. Subordinate point (level 4)

2. Subordinate point (level 1)

II. MAIN POINT

A. Subordinate point (level 1)

B. Subordinate point (level 1)

1. Subordinate point (level 2)

2. Subordinate point (level 2)

III. MAIN POINT

CONCLUSION

Main points + deeper truth



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II. Organization

Part 1: Introduction

1. A **hook** that grabs the reader's attention



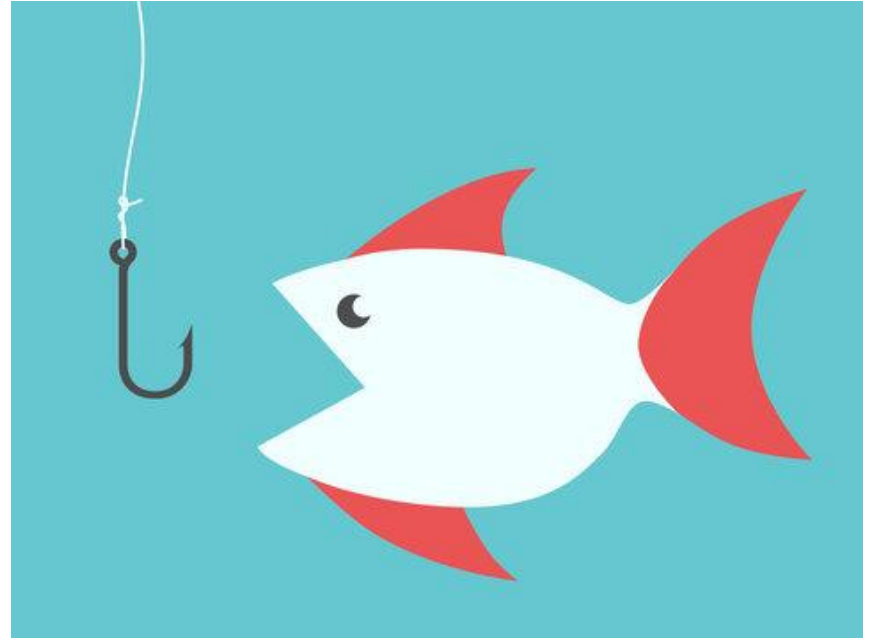
What is a **hook**?

◆ In real life, a hook is...



◆ In writing, a hook is...

- a device used to catch the reader's attention.
- It is often the **opening sentence** of an essay.



Six types of hooks

- a. Definition
- b. Quote from a famous person
- c. Question
- d. Statement that shocks, surprises, or muses
- e. Dilemma/conflict
- f. Comparison (simile or metaphor)

Hook Matching Game



Examples of different types of hook

1. Imagine you could have one superpower; what would you want it to be?
2. Many people have been fascinated by Superman's good looks and his dark hair. But Superman was supposed to be a bald character, obsessed with dominating the world.
3. Joseph Campbell, a professor of literature, states, "A hero is someone who has given his or her life to something bigger than themselves."
4. The Cambridge dictionary defines superhero movies as a genre of movies that features "a character with special strength and using it to help other people". Such movies have soared far beyond simple action flicks. Today, they serve as modern myths—reflecting society's hopes, fears, and values—while dominating global box offices and shaping pop culture conversations around the world.
5. With superpowers, superheroes can save the world with a single decision, but they also wrestle with impossible choices when saving one life means risking thousands.
6. Superman soars into the sky like a bullet.



Compare the two versions of a hook for an essay about a vacation experience.

1. It **was** a bad vacation.
2. It might seem unlikely to **catch** the flu, **lose** a wallet, and **get** a speeding ticket in one afternoon, but these incidents **ruined** a vacation.

Source: *Great Writing 5*



Language Use

- ◆ TIP 1. “Show, not tell”: use **descriptive language**—that is, describe people, places, things, and ideas that you refer to, and do not simply name them.



Compare these descriptions.

1. The wind was **extremely strong**.
2. The wind bent my umbrella **totally out of shape**, and every step **took extra effort**. It shoved hard against my body, making my jacket **flap noisily** and blowing my hair into my face.



Language Use

◆ TIP 2. Use five senses

- **A. Sight**—Paint a word picture of what you are describing. Try to do this well enough that if your audience reads your words and later encounters the same scene for the first time, they will have an “Aha!” moment of recognition,
- **B. Sounds**—If appropriate, describe what you heard or hear in the situation you are writing about.
- **C. Touch, smell and taste**—If appropriate, describe these sensations as well.



Please create engaging hooks for the following personal essay title:
The biggest challenge

◆ **Quotation Hook**

- ◆ “Courage is not having the strength to go on; it is going on when you don’t have the strength.” – Theodore Roosevelt

◆ **Question Hook**

- ◆ Have you ever faced something so hard you were not sure you would get through it?

◆ **Metaphor/Simile Hook**

- ◆ Some challenges feel like storms—you just have to keep moving until they pass.

◆ **Statement/Statistic Hook**

- ◆ One in three people grows the most from life’s hardest challenges.



II. Organization

Para 1: Introduction

1. a **hook** that grabs the reader's attention

2. the **topic** of the essay



e.g., the challenge, the most unforgettable moment



II. Organization

Para 1: Introduction

1. a **hook** that grabs the reader's attention
2. the **topic** of the essay
3. a **thesis statement**



A **thesis statement** in a **personal essay** typically reflects a lesson, realization, or perspective you've gained from your personal experience.



Identify the problems with these theses for personal essays.

1. *This experience changed me.*
2. *Travel broadens the mind.*
3. *Failing my first math exam in college reminded me of something important.*



How to craft an effective thesis for a personal essay

- ◆ **Be specific:** Instead of a **vague** or **generic** statement, focus on a **particular** experience or lesson.
 - Weak: *This experience changed me.*
 - Strong: *This experience taught me the value of empathy and the significance of small acts of kindness.*



How to craft an effective thesis for a personal essay

- ◆ **Make it personal:** The thesis should reflect **your unique perspective**, making it clear this is **your** story.
 - Generic: *Travel broadens the mind.*
 - Personal: *Traveling solo through Japan taught **me** how to find comfort in my own company and embrace the unknown.*



How to craft an effective thesis for a personal essay

- ◆ **Highlight a *lesson* or theme:** A strong thesis connects your personal story to a broader idea or insight.
 - Example: *Failing my first math exam in college reminded me that **success is not about natural talent—it is about perseverance and the willingness to ask for help.***



Some example **thesis statements** in personal essays

- ◆ **Overcoming my fear of public speaking** taught me that confidence is not about being fearless, but about embracing vulnerability and stepping outside my comfort zone.
- ◆ **Surviving my first year away from home** was more than just a test of independence—it was a journey of self-discovery that taught me how to adapt, grow, and lean on others for support.
- ◆ **Losing my best friend** to an unexpected illness made me realize the fragility of life and the importance of cherishing every moment with those we love.



Where does the thesis go in a personal essay?

- ◆ Typically, the thesis appears at the end of the **introduction** to set the tone and context for the essay.
- ◆ However, a personal essay is often more **reflective** and **fluid**. In some personal essays, the thesis may emerge **later in the essay**, especially if the narrative builds toward a realization or conclusion.



II. Organization

Last Para.: Conclusion

- Summarize the writer's main points/restate the thesis and contain the **moral** of your story or a **revelation** of a deeper truth.
- Should **NOT** include any new information



Task 3. Please complete the following outline for the Topic “The Biggest Challenge in My Life.”

Introduction	
Hook: Thesis:	
Body paragraphs (key moments)	
Body 1	
Body 2	
Body 3	
Conclusion	
Restate: Reflect:	



Introduction

Hook: A vivid moment from the challenge.

Thesis: The challenge + the lesson in one sentence.

Body paragraphs (key moments)

Body 1	Describe the challenge (use sensory details)
Body 2	Key actions I took to overcome it (focus on 1–2 actions).
Body 3	The lesson and how it changed me (link it to the process).

Conclusion

Restate/Reflect: Who am I now because of this experience?
How did this experience impact me?

